

In a world where talking about money is considered taboo or tacky, money problems are personal failings, and no one wants to hear us complain. It's no wonder that we find ourselves confused and struggling, in need of someone to blow an air horn in our faces. We have to open up about our experiences with money—the good, the bad, and especially the ugly. Otherwise there's nothing specific to learn. In fact, if you listen closely, you'll notice that so-called money experts hardly ever use exact amounts. Speaking in specifics is risky, but speaking in platitudes appeals to broader audiences.

No one likes admitting they're doing something wrong, or that they might not know what they're doing at all. I felt the same way: I thought everything was my fault, and I didn't want to be yelled at. I hate being judged as if I'm ignorant for not knowing something “obvious.” I would do anything to avoid that judgment. I'd denounce Janelle Monáe. Climb the Andes naked. Brush my teeth with salt rocks.

I want to be able to talk about the ways the system is stacked against us, without worrying about being labeled “lazy.” My research has led me to conclude that (1) the system is definitely stacked against us (unless you're a millionaire who picked up this book to mock *me* personally) but that (2) there are positive steps we can take to make our money lives easier within that very flawed system.

The prevailing narrative goes that if you're bad with money, you're naive and irresponsible or defective in some other big way. Because of that, you should keep that information to yourself, and if anyone finds out that you're bad with money, you should be ashamed. MOREOVER: If you're not actively trying to change your situation with intense strategies like strict budgets and financial fad diets that no person can possibly maintain forever, then you're a bad person who deserves the bad situation you've found yourself in. The only thing people love more than having money is judging other people for how they're using their money. (Example: “My money situation isn't great but at least I'm not like my irresponsible cousin Terry! Why do you have an Equinox membership if you never go to the gym, Terry?!”)

This narrative is an extension of the prosperity gospel, which posits that if you are truly a good, smart, and worthy person, you will magically prosper. Even